According to YouTube creator **John Dawson**, mastering **five fundamental manual tools** provides the essential **skill sets and muscle memory** required to construct almost anything independently. The guide outlines the practical applications of a **level, speed square, pry bar, hammer, and tape measure**, emphasising their collective importance for both everyday construction and self-sufficiency scenarios. By learning how to properly operate these **non-powered instruments**, individuals can successfully accomplish basic framing, alignment, and measuring tasks without relying on modern technology.

a hammer is a tool that a lot of people don't know how to use nowadays I I'll just be honest with you I I uh on on on the gram on the Instagram on the Tik Tok I I'm fairly known as a competent hammer wielder Um I am fairly good with the hammer I framed a 4,000 ft uh build with just a hammer Um not because I had to but because I thought it was fun What is up everybody If you don't know my name is John Dawson and I do a lot of things and that's all you really need to know Now I want to go over five tools that you must have and must know how to use in my opinion And just to answer your question it is some type of pryar or cat's paw a hammer doesn't really matter what kind of hammer a tape measure a speed square and a level If you can use these tools and assuming that you know how to do this with a handsaw I wasn't going to put that in here because if you don't know how to use a handsaw go learn Um but if you can use these five tools you can pretty much build anything right So the the reason why I chose these tools is because the coordination that all of these tools take and the and the knowledge that these tools take transcribe to almost everything in building It's just these t these skill sets and muscle memories repeated in different with different tools and different aspects of a build So starting with the level right Obviously a level can make things level by sitting Let's move these out of the way So obviously a level can make things level What level means is flat this way Okay So level means that you are level going horizontally right So a level can do that It can also plum Now what is plum Plum is basically a vertical level So when you put your level like this this means plum when you're going vertical right So horizontal is level vertical is plum I've been building for 15 years and I'll just tell you this right now I still sometimes say level when I mean plum Um most people will know what you mean The comments will will get after you but in the end if you and whoever you're working with understands don't sweat it Try to do it right But you know most of us understand that if we're working on a column and you say level I know you mean plum But this is plum This is level If you can do this you can pretty much frame an entire house and make sure that it's level and plum Now the other thing that you can do with a level is you can find fall So if you have to make drainage or you're doing a French drain where you are trying to stop water from flooding into an area you can do fall There's these two lines here on the on the level And when that bubble is splitting those lines by you know a quarter of a bubble a half of a bubble or you're a full bubble off then you know that you have a certain amount of fall Now we can get into the numbers of where that bubble is and how many degrees of fall you have Be it a quarter inch per foot uh you know an inch per foot whatever it is but overall as long as you are about half a bubble on your line you know you have good fall as long as you're not using like a 1in pipe In that case I would probably go with a full bubble just because oneinch pipe will need a little bit more gravity to push that water through cleanly and smoothly without backing up But I don't know why you'd be using a one-inch pipe for drainage anyway But I'm just saying this level can plum it can level and it can give you fall for drainage So know how to use this It's not complicated Everything I just told

you is pretty much all you need to know So there you go The next thing is a speed square Now I have my custommade This is my my speed square I'll put a link below if you guys want to get it If not I wouldn't And let me just say this real quick This is a custom speed square that is John Dawson and it's the the dark and bronze with the black speed square This one actually got a bunch of concrete on it Oops sorry Um but this is a very high-end speed square with a lot of technology here in the middle If you don't know how to utilize all this technology go buy yourself a Swanson at Home Depot Go buy yourself a cheap Empire or an Ox Tool speed square You don't need to spend 150 bucks on a speed square like this if you're not going to utilize it It's a waste of money As much as I would love for you to go buy this and I get to get paid for making these videos um if you're not going to utilize it I don't want you to buy it I'm not here to make money off you I'm here to make you better at whatever it is that you're trying to do So if you're starting out go get the cheapest one you can find I used Swanson for 8 years before I ever got any other type of speed square I still have that Swanson speed square It's has the price has nothing to do with durability longevity It's purely if you want more things on it Like I like my level on here I don't carry a torpedo level anymore So this is a level and a speed square which comes in really handy with what I do But overall a speed square a speed square obviously is a triangle Uh two 90s right make a corner right So you have a 90 uh here This is your 90 line And then you also have your 45° line which will give you the 45° angle So that's going to give you the majority of what you would need to cut things to square things up Now you can get into your common rafter hip and valley uh when you get into the middle of the speed square and working on your degrees I wouldn't dive into that if you've never used a speed square You just want to figure out how to cut your straight 90s how to cut your 45s and then you can start getting into different degrees as you want to But overall this will be great for just getting your 90s and your 45s which if you're in a survival situation or if you're in uh just figure it out and get it done situation mostly you can build something using 45s and 90s um it's not it's not a big deal you're gonna have basically a 90 degree or a 45 degree pitch is a 1212 which means you climb 12 inches for every 12 inches you go in Um and that's perfectly fine if you're just trying to throw something together So a speed square is something that you need to get and learn how to use cuz you never know when that skill will come in handy The next thing is some type of crowbar or cat's paw I would recommend a pry bar crowbar whatever you want to call it It's a little bit bigger It can do a lot more things um in a survival sense in a building sense This is going to be easier to get things done This is going to be more compact to carry around with you Okay So um regardless learn how to use them Learn how to get in there pop a nail up learn how to pry lumber away uh apart The the technique that I will say that a lot of people don't know is if you get under here and you don't have the ability to pry up like this If you can get in there and twist twist your bar like this you can start that nail popping out and then you can pry it out like this So learn how to use this Same thing with the back If you can get it under there say you hammer it in with your hammer you can twist this way to pop that up a little bit then you get that leverage to where you can start popping it out this way So learning how to use one of these is not hard it's not difficult but it can do a lot of things You can also flip these around and use them as a little nail set if you if you need to It's not ideal but you can use these for a lot of different things Um they're just a really good piece of steel and they can kind of be used for whatever you need a piece of steel for So having one of these is is a smart thing to have and know how to use it The next thing is a hammer A

hammer is a tool that a lot of people don't know how to use nowadays I I'll just be honest with you I I uh on on on the gram on the Instagram on the TikTok I I'm fairly known as a competent hammer wielder Um I am fairly good with the hammer I framed a 4,000 foot uh build with just a hammer Um not because I had to but because I thought it was fun Um and I I just love I just love swinging a hammer If you practice swinging a hammer you're going to find it to be very very fun So it doesn't matter what hammer you have It It really doesn't matter This is a curved grip Milwaukee uh wood-handled hammer Probably 25 bucks It's a great hammer Um I highly recommend it if you just want to figure out how to use a hammer and get the muscle memory down It's crazy Learning how to use a hammer is one of the most primitive easy things that most men used to know how to do whether you worked in construction or not And nowadays people can't even do it So what I would recommend is getting a hammer learning how to use a hammer Um because you can build everything with a hammer Right nowadays we have nail guns we have impact drivers we have all these other types of fastening uh techniques but in the end if it came down to it a hammer and some nails are going to get the job done So learning how to use a hammer you don't need solar you don't need battery you don't need anything but your arm and some nails and this will get done what you got to get done So I highly recommend everyone becoming good with a hammer It's very simple I can't really teach you here on a video It's just muscle memory You just need to get some get some nails and learn how to hit Now what I will say is a lot of people grab it way down here at the base Some people choke up top The sweet spot is here in the middle It's kind of right where the hand fits And everyone thinks that it's this huge swing It's not You're going to go you're going to get your rhythm And as I get my rhythm I'm bringing the hammer up a little bit higher each time because I know my spot So it's tap tap tap tap drive And then I'm done So this is something that I think everyone should learn how to use It's very important The last one and not the least one is a tape measure You need to know how to read a tape measure Okay I don't need you to be able to call out 16 and eighs and and 1/4 in in a matter of a half a second Um if you're not a builder every day but you should be able to read a tape measure right With a tape measure you have 1in marks you have 16th marks you have eighs eighs you have um quarters you have halves So basically when you think about it an inch is made up of technically 17 lines if you're going inch to inch but it's 16 lines which would be your 16s And then you break that down and there's 88 right 88s It's just fractions And then you have uh four quarters right 1 2 3 4 makes an inch 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 makes an inch Um 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 19 11 12 13 14 15 16 makes an inch So the smallest lines are the 16ths The second to smallest lines are going to be your eighths The third to smallest lines are going to be your quarters and your largest line in the middle is going to be your/ inch It's very simple A lot of people over complicate it Again if you can use a hammer and a nail if you can use a catpaw if you can use a speed square and if you can use a level then you can build pretty much whatever you want Now it's not going to be a luxury custom home but you can put something together um without any problems So these five tools a tape measure a hammer a cat's paw or pry bar a speed square and a level can get most jobs done with no problem Anyway guys I appreciate you guys for watching Let me know in the comment section if you have tools that you would swap out or add I would love to hear what you guys think and what you would use if you could only choose five tools to have with you to build something and put something together Much love y'all I'll see you all in next